

Working With AI Code: Do / Don't

Companion sheet to "Calibrated Trust in Agentic Coding." Tape this next to the monitor.

Reviewing a diff

Do	Don't
Ask "why does this work," not just "does it work."	Merge because a diff runs clean without knowing why the old code failed.
Have it explain the fix in design-review terms: what could break this, what was rejected.	Accept an explanation that only restates the code in English.
Push back if the explanation is vague or shifts when re-asked.	Treat confident-sounding prose as proof of correctness.

Understanding a bug

Do	Don't
Request the smallest possible repro before accepting the patch.	Read a 200-line diff and assume you've absorbed the logic.
Trace the repro by hand, at least once, for anything you're fuzzy on.	Move on the moment the symptom disappears.

Building confidence

Do	Don't
Write or request a test for the exact edge case that confused you.	Let "it passed this run" stand in for "it's correct."
Treat test coverage as the understanding you can't hold in your head.	Skip tests because the AI already seems sure.

Where to spend scrutiny

Do	Don't
Go hands-on for state, concurrency, resource allocation, security, anything with money.	Apply the same light touch everywhere regardless of blast radius.
Move fast on low-stakes, easily-checked output (formatting, boilerplate, simple queries).	Interrogate trivial code as hard as high-stakes code — that's wasted effort, not rigor.

One-line test before you accept anything: could you defend this in a code review using your own words, not the AI's?